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Region: Africa

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Section Title(S): The Mother And Mother's Kin

This relationship is cordial and intimate: the Shona refer to it as *ukama hwokutamba* ('a relationship of playing') and anthropologists call it a joking relationship. The sister's son can normally avail himself of anything belonging to his mother's brother without even asking for it, and no action should be taken against him. A sister's son has a degree of freedom and privilege in the homesteads of his mother's brothers which he would never have in the homesteads of senior members of his own lineage.²⁴ There are, however, limits to this freedom: a man would sue his sister's sons for such crimes as adultery with his wife or serious theft of his property. Some respect is due to the mother's brother, especially on first acquaintance;²⁵ familiarity develops later, and even then a sister's son should treat his mother's brother with a mixture of deference and equality depending on the circumstances.

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From the point of view of the lineage of the mother's  50 brother, a sister's son belongs to another lineage and is not personally involved in any of the rivalries over authority, property, inheritance or any other conflicts that may arise within their own family group. Yet he is a close kinsman with the consequent mutual obligations of loyalty and aid, and is thus in an ideal position to arbitrate in family conflicts. The ties between the families are ideally strengthened by the passage of cattle: the bride-price paid by a man should be used for the marriage of his wife's brother. One marriage makes the other possible. Thus among the Hera a <i>muzukuru</i> might jokingly say to younger members of his mother's lineage, 'You are my children because your mother is my "wife". Was she not married with my [i.e., my father's] cattle?' To his maternal relatives the sister's son is <i>mwana mukati</i>, which Professor Holleman translates freely as 'a child that somehow belongs "inside" his mother's lineage because it is of the same blood', and a man may declare that he loves his sister's son more than his own. ²⁶		102 Maps
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24 Holleman 1949, pp. 12ff.; Garbett 1963a, p. 164.

25 Boas (1922) in his analysis of the Ndau kinship system places more emphasis on the authoritative position of the mother's brother and claims that the term *sekuru* derives from the fact that a woman is considered a daughter of her lineage: thus any male of a man's mother's lineage has the status of grandparent.

26 Holleman 1952, pp. 67f. Some of Professor Holleman's remarks appear to be peculiar to the Hera people.

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